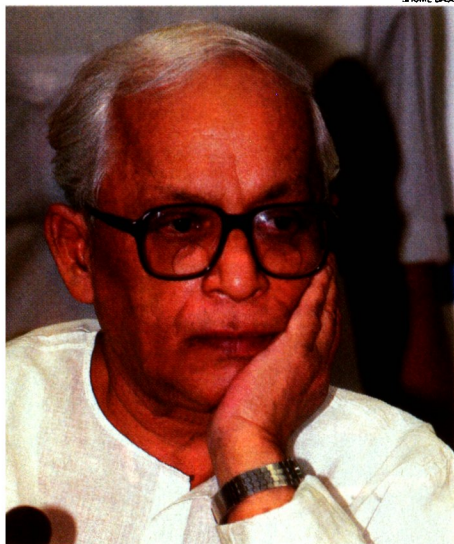


LEAVING THE FUTURE

The Tata pullout from Singur raises doubts about the future of more than 60 projects with investments nearing Rs 2 lakh crore

SHOME BASU



■ By Nivedita Mukherjee and Elora Sen

Considering the unremitting zeal with which Buddhadeb Bhattacharya pursued the Nano, it appeared the small car was to him what the nuclear deal was to Prime Minister Manmohan Singh. He had invested enormous political capital to ensure that West Bengal was home to the world's cheapest car. For Bhattacharya, the Nano was not just about the 10,000-jobs, both direct and indirect, that would have been created in and around Singur, the small car was also the biggest test of the credibility of his determined campaign to brush aside what he called the state's "wasted years". "The world is changing

and we must adapt ourselves," Chinese president Jiang Zemin had told the Communist Congress before demitting office. From the day he took office, he tried to do that by rolling out investor-friendly policies that would free his state from the dogmatic rules of Marxism. A rollout of the Nano from Singur this Diwali would have been the most coveted badge of approval for him.

Bhattacharya's dreams lie in tatters as Tata Motors last week announced the relocation of the mother plant of the Nano from Singur to Sanand in Gujarat. With the Nano gone, there is once again fear that West Bengal may slip into industrial isolation. Bengal's and Bhattacharya's misery go beyond

the Nano. "Brand Buddha" may have been the buzzword for young voters and investors, but when it came to championing the cause of Bengal's industrialisation, Bhattacharya failed miserably. The chief minister wanted growth and jobs, Trinamool Congress Chief Mamata Banerjee wanted an issue that would pull her out of political morass. The list of those caught in the crossfire and lost out is long—the Salim Group of Indonesia, Reliance Retail were the first. Also facing uncertainty now is the German retail giant Metro Cash & Carry which started constructing a 1,00,000-sq-ft outlet in southeast of Kolkata a couple of years back. With Left Front partners